CHAPTER 1

Posture & Hand Shape

Before the first note: how to sit, and how to hold your hands. Get these right, and every note after them is easier.



Sit tall, like a puppet on a string

In this chapter

- [ ] Sit at the piano — page 2
- [ ] Let the arm carry the hand — page 3
- [ ] A round hand — page 4
- [ ] Finger numbers — page 5
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By the end, you can

- [ ] sit at the right height and distance
- [ ] move your hand with the whole arm
- [ ] make a round hand and play on the tips
- [ ] say every finger number, on both hands

ONLINE

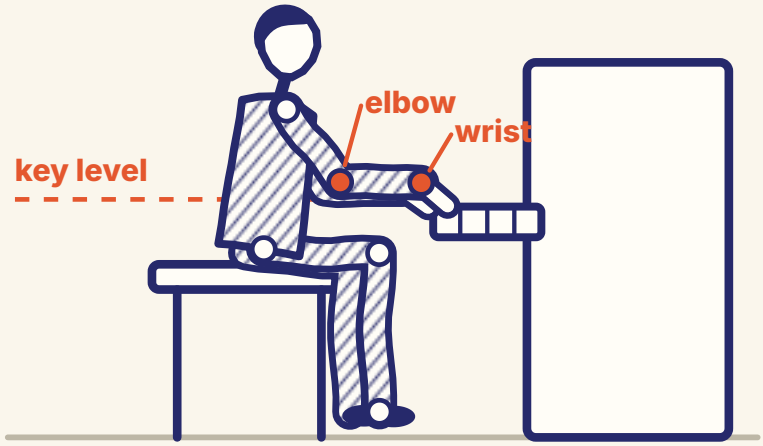
The lesson and the drill. Scan, pick a level, aim for 9 out of 10.

1. Is the stool set up right? __/10
2. Spot the hand-shape fault __/10
3. Which finger? __/10

Step 1

Sit at the piano

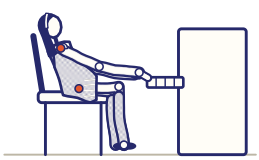
Two things to set: **how high** and **how far**. Your forearm is level with the keys, and your elbows sit just in front of your body.



At the piano

1. Sit on the **front half of the stool**, feet flat on the floor, leaning a little toward the piano. ☐
2. Raise or lower the stool until your **forearm is level** with the keys. ☐
3. Slide in or out until your **elbows are just in front of you**, about a fist away from your sides. ☐

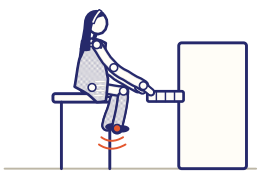
Not like this



× Leaning back, like on a sofa



× So close the elbows squash in



× Too high: feet swinging

REMEMBER **Front half of the stool, feet flat, sit tall, leaning a little forward.**

Lesson step 1

online

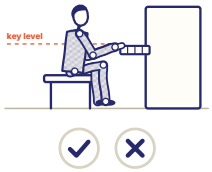
TRY IT Is this a good set-up?

Look at each picture, then try it at the piano. Circle the tick or the cross.

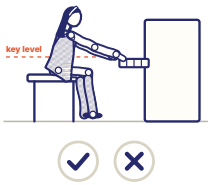
EXAMPLE



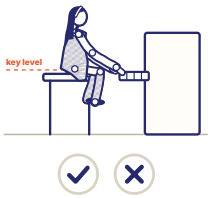
2



3



4



YOUR TURN Set up at home

Before you practise, set up and tick each one. Ask someone at home to check, or use a mirror.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
Front half of the stool	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Feet flat, leaning a little toward the piano	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sit tall, like a puppet on a string	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Forearm level with the keys	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Elbows away from your body	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

★ PLAY Draw yourself at the piano

Draw yourself sitting at the piano. Then colour a star for each thing you drew.

☆ sitting tall
☆ feet flat
☆ leaning a little forward
☆ elbows away from the body
☆ round hands

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Step 2

Let the arm carry the hand

Your fingertips stay connected to the piano, but the **whole arm** does the work: from above, it leads the hand and the fingers. Six moves, **in this order**, from the big parts of the body to the small ones: each one gets the arm ready for the next.



1 Rag doll

Flop forward and let both arms hang heavy. Shake them loose, then float the hands up and set them gently on the keys.



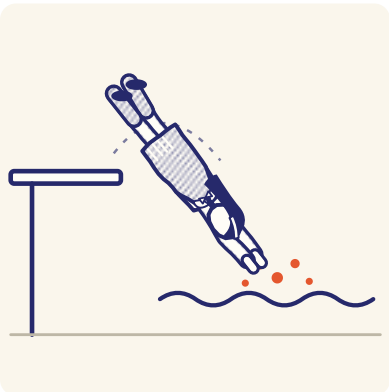
2 Elbow wings

Check the elbows are free, not stuck to your body: let them float out like wings, then back. Stop in the middle, a fist from your body.



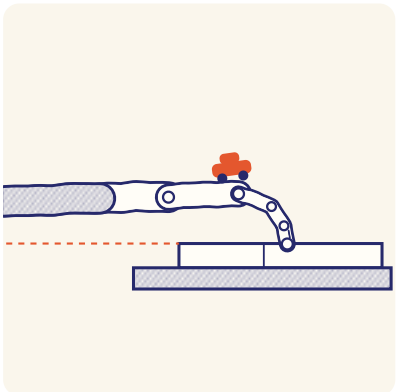
3 Arm glide

Now the whole arm: skate along the keys. The round hand rides on the arm to the next group of keys. The fingers ride, they don't walk.



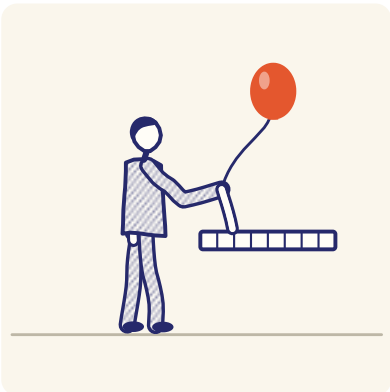
4 Arm drop

Lift the whole arm and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm tip, soft wrist, a round sound.



5 Knuckle bridge

Check the bridge: your knuckles are a bridge a little car can drive over. Press one key slowly and hold for 3: the bridge stays up.



6 Wrist balloon

Check the wrist never sinks: as the key goes down, a balloon lifts the wrist straight back up to level. The fingertip stays on the key.

REMEMBER **The arm leads from above, elbows free. Even while a finger presses a key, the whole arm stays free.**

Lesson step 2 online

TRY IT Put the warm-ups in order

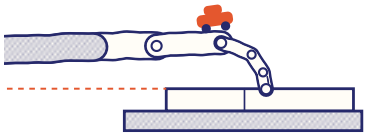
Big parts of the body first, small parts last. Write 1 to 6 under the pictures. The first one is done.

EXAMPLE



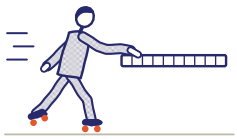
Rag doll 1

2



Knuckle bridge

3



Arm glide

4



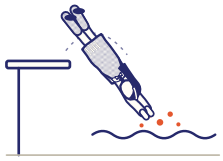
Wrist balloon

5



Elbow wings

6



Arm drop

YOUR TURN My warm-ups this week

Do the six in order before you practise. Tick a box for each one you did.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
1 Rag doll	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 Elbow wings	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 Arm glide	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4 Arm drop	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5 Knuckle bridge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6 Wrist balloon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

YOUR TURN Yes or no?

Circle yes or no.

1 **The arm leads from above.** yes no

2 **My elbows stay stuck to my body.** yes no

3 **Even while a finger presses a key, the whole arm stays free.** yes no

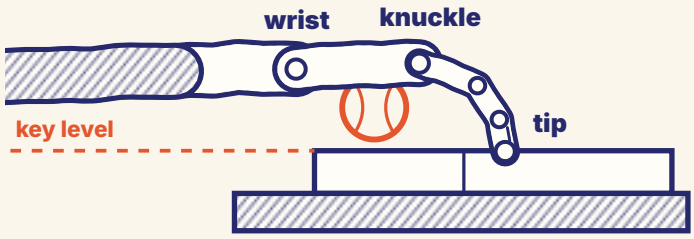
4 **After a key goes down, my wrist sinks below the keys.** yes no

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

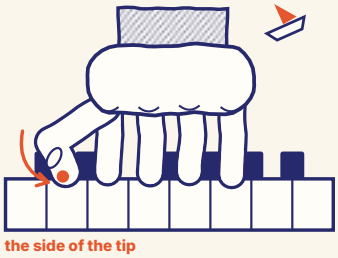
Step 3

A round hand

Let your arms hang, then lift your hands as if you were holding a small ball. Keep that shape when the hand goes on the keys. **Knuckles up** like a bridge, and play on the **fingertips**. The wrist stays free: with the fingertip on the key, the hand can sway up and down and side to side, as if a **roller** sat under your forearm.



Round, like holding a ball

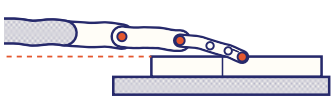


The thumb bends in and plays on the side of its tip, like a tipped boat

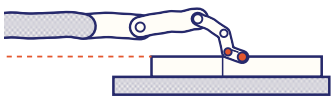
At the piano

1. Hands on your knees. Hold an imaginary ball. ☐
2. Move the ball shape onto the keys without squashing it. ☐
3. Play one key with each finger, on the tip. The knuckles stay up. ☐
4. Fingertip on a key: sway the wrist up and down, then side to side, as if on a roller. Notice the knuckles and the tip, and try not to let them cave in. ☐

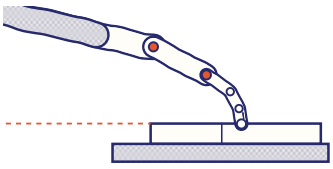
Not like this



× Flat fingers



× Tip joint caving in



× Wrist stiff and high

REMEMBER **A free wrist, as if on a roller. Keep an eye on the knuckles and fingertips.**

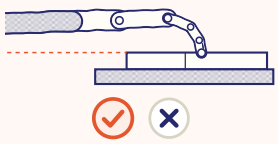
Lesson step 3

online

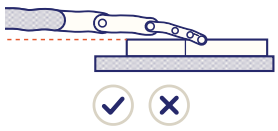
TRY IT Spot the good hand

Circle the tick for the good hand shape and the cross for a fault. Then say what is wrong.

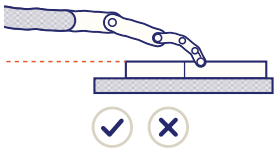
EXAMPLE



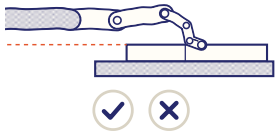
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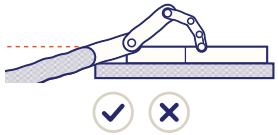
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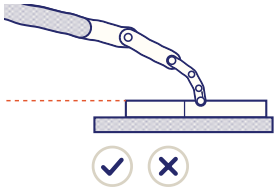
4



5



6



YOUR TURN Roller wrist and thumb

Do each one at the piano and tick a box each day.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
Fingertip on a key: sway the wrist up and down, then side to side	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Knuckles up, like a bridge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The thumb bends in and plays on the side of its tip	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

★ PLAY Hold the bubble

Hold a small ball (or a mandarin) in a round hand. Draw your hand round it, then colour a star for each.

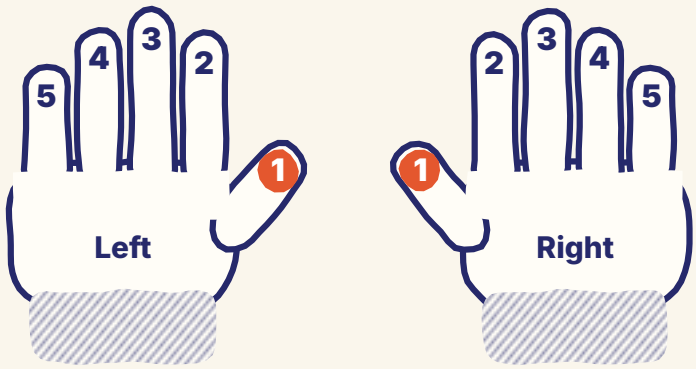
- ☆ knuckles up
- ☆ round fingers
- ☆ playing on the tips
- ☆ the thumb on its side

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Step 4

Finger numbers

Every finger has a number, **1 to 5, starting from the thumb**. It's the same on both hands: both thumbs are 1, and both little fingers are 5.



1 Captain Thumb **2 Pointer** **3 Tall Middle** **4 Shy Ring** **5 Baby Pinky**

The mirror game

1. Hold both hands up. Wiggle each finger as you say its number. ☐
2. Someone calls "Right hand, 3!" and you wiggle it. Try ten calls. ☐
3. Swap: you call the finger, and they wiggle it. ☐



REMEMBER **Fingers are numbered 1 to 5 from the thumb, on both hands.**

Lesson step 4

online

TRY IT Which finger?

Write the number of the coloured finger. Thumbs are 1 on both hands.

EXAMPLE



4

2



3



4



5



6



★ PLAY Trace your hands

Put each hand flat in its box and draw round it. Write the finger numbers on every finger -- the thumb is 1 on both hands! Then draw a ring on each finger 4.

Left hand

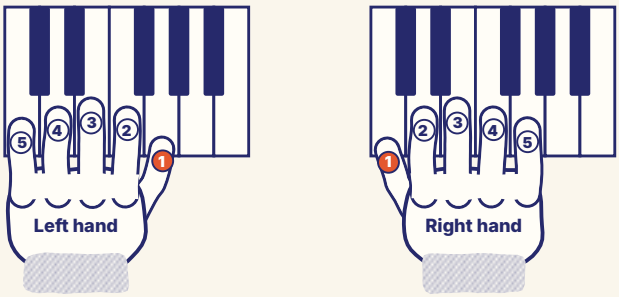
Right hand

Check: ☐ 5 fingers on each hand ☐ Thumbs are 1 ☐ A ring round each finger 4
☐ Left and right the right way round

Play

Finger walks

Now put it together: sit well, make a round hand, and play. **Start small:** one note, then two, three, four, and all five. From key to key, the hand draws a little **rainbow**: relaxed, never squeezed tight, the whole hand helping. **One circle is one steady beat.**





Hop on 3

one note: an arm drop on every 3

3 ○ 3 ○ | 3 3 3 ○



Neighbours

two notes, next door, taking turns

2 3 2 3 | 3 2 3 ○



Up and back

three notes: up, then back down

1 2 3 ○ | 3 2 1 ○



Little hill

four notes: up the hill and down

1 2 3 4 | 3 2 1 ○



Stairs and slide

all five: up the stairs, then down the slide

1 2 3 4 5 ○ | 5 4 3 2 1 ○

An empty dashed circle means: hold the note for one more beat.



REMEMBER **A little rainbow from key to key. Relaxed: the whole hand helps.**

Lesson step 5

online

TRY IT Fill in the missing numbers

Write the missing finger numbers in the coral circles, then play the tune. The first one is done.

Up and back — 1 2 **3** ◯ | 3 ◯ 1 ◯

Little hill — 1 2 ◯ 4 | ◯ 2 1 ◯

Stairs and slide — 1 2 3 ◯ 5 ◯ | 5 ◯ 3 2 1 ◯

YOUR TURN Finger walks this week

Play each tune. Tick it when the hand stays round and draws a little rainbow from key to key.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
1 Hop on 3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 Neighbours	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 Up and back	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4 Little hill	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5 Stairs and slide	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

★ PLAY Make your own finger walk

Write a finger number (1 to 5) in each circle. Leave a circle empty to hold the note. Play it to someone!

◯ ◯ ◯ ◯ | ◯ ◯ ◯ ◯

My tune is called _____

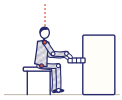
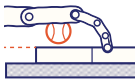
How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Check-up

My five checks

At the piano: before you play, every time -- give yourself a star for each check in each lesson. On paper: do the check-up below.

At the piano

		Lesson 1	2	3	4	5	6
	**Front half of the stool**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	**Feet flat, leaning a little toward the piano**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	**Sit tall, like a puppet on a string**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	**Forearm level with the keys, elbows away from your body**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	**Round hand, play on the tips**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

On paper

Name _____ Date _____ · no help, no piano · about 10 minutes

A A good set-up? Circle the tick or the cross.

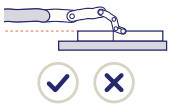
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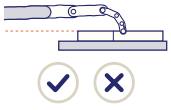
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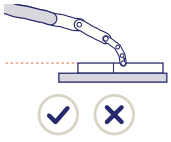
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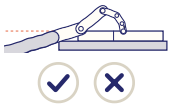
4 

B A good hand shape? Circle the tick or the cross.

5 

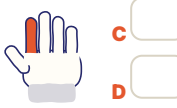
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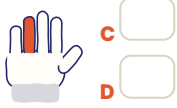
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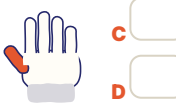
8 

C Left or right hand? Write L or R. D Which finger is coloured?

9 · 13 
C ☐
D ☐

10 · 14 
C ☐
D ☐

11 · 15 
C ☐
D ☐

12 · 16 
C ☐
D ☐

E Finger walks: write the missing number.

17 (1) (2) (3) ( ) (5)

18 (5) (4) ( ) (2) (1)

19 (2) (3) (2) ( )

20 (1) ( ) (3) (2) (1)